

A murder plot

Caesar's pragmatic solutions for reestablishing unity in the empire after years of chaos found favor with many parts of society, yet at the same time, his increasingly autocratic attitude to power was alienating fellow members of the ruling class. They felt that Caesar was trying to destroy the cherished traditions of the Roman state, and to undermine the prestige of the nobility, and spread the rumor that he was planning to make himself king. Unfortunately, Caesar failed to quell the suspicions. He accepted unprecedented honors, such as assuming the title "Imperator" ("Victorious General") as a family name; he also allowed temples and statues to be erected in his honor, and had coins minted bearing his image. And when he adopted his grand-nephew, Octavian, there were fears that he was trying to establish a dynastic succession. Some members of the Senate concluded that the only solution to the problem was to assassinate Caesar, and so they hatched a conspiracy to carry it out.

Representing those opposed to the dictator's reforms—and the leading agent in the plot to murder him—Gaius Cassius Longinus was a general who had risen to political prominence during a largely disastrous campaign in Persia. Ancient Roman historians argued that Cassius's involvement was prompted by a combination of jealousy and greed. He is also said to have recruited the most important conspirator, Marcus Junius Brutus, a trusted colleague and confidante of Caesar, opposed to the dictator's presumed monarchic ambitions.

Death of a dictator

The assassination plot grew rapidly, eventually including 60 senators, among them many of Caesar's close colleagues. The plotters decided to strike at a meeting of the Senate that had been called for March 15, (the Ides of March). On the day, they gathered at Cassius's home, each senator concealing a dagger beneath his robes, before moving on to Pompey's Theater—part of a great civic complex that

Caesar's old rival had constructed—where the Senate was meeting. A group of gladiators had been stationed in the theater itself, to help control any crowd problems. However, many of the conspirators were nervous and ready to flee, convinced that the plot had been uncovered.

Caesar had indeed been warned: a list of the plotters had been thrust into his hands, but he ignored it. His wife pleaded with him not to attend the Senate meeting, but one of the conspirators, stationed at Caesar's house, helped calm her fears. When Caesar arrived at the meeting, a conspirator distracted his deputy, Mark Antony, delaying him outside the theater. As Caesar took his seat, the conspirators drew their daggers and struck, stabbing him 23 times. In an ironic twist, Caesar breathed his last slumped against the base of a statue of his old rival Pompey.

The Second Triumvirate

Seized with manic fervor, the conspirators dipped their hands in Caesar's blood and rushed out into the Forum to proclaim their tyrannicide. In the power vacuum that followed, Mark Antony, and Caesar's heir, Octavian, promptly assumed control of the state, forming in 43 BCE a triumvirate (a group of three men holding power) with Lepidus, one of Caesar's former allies.

Needing to gather enough funds to stabilize their authority, and to remove political opposition, the triumvirate drew up a list of those who had supported Caesar's murderers, and declared them outlaws. Around 200 senators and more than 2,000 equites ("knights" or minor nobility) were either killed or had their estates confiscated. The treasury's coffers now filled, the triumvirate hunted down and destroyed Brutus and Cassius.

In 40 BCE, the triumvirs met again, this time to carve up the Roman world. Africa was given to Lepidus, the East to Mark Antony, and the West to Octavian. However, it was not long before Octavian went to war against Antony in north Africa, and, after defeating his forces